Upside Down Kingdom 2

Week 4 — 10/20/26

Matthew 5:27–37

Beatitudes 5:3–12	3 Hope Images 5:13–16	**Antitheses 5:17–48**	Righteous Practices 6:1–20	Parallel Discourses 6:21–7:12	3 Warning Images 7:13–27

REVIEW OF LAST WEEK

- Jesus gives his primary rule of the Christian ethic: start inward and see what fruits bear naturally out of it; this is the heart of the Torah.
- Anger clouds our "right-vision" of seeing others as sons of God; forgiveness de-clouds and reconciliation is restoration of kingdom-relationships.

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (PT.1) (NET)

a **27** You have heard that it was said,
b 'Do not commit adultery.'
a' **28** But I say to you that
b' whoever looks at a woman to desire (epithymēsai) her
c has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
a **29** If your right eye causes you to sin,
b tear it out and throw it away!
c It is better to lose one of your members than to have your whole body thrown into hell.
a' **30** If your right hand causes you to sin,
b cut it off and throw it away!
c It is better to lose one of your members than to have your whole body go into hell.

INDIVIDUALS' TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

27 You have heard that **it was said**,
"You shall not commit adultery";
28 **and I say** to you that
everyone who goes on looking at a woman in order to cultivate lust for her,
he has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
29 If your right eye causes your downfall,
tear it out and throw it from you;
for it is better for you to lose one of your body-parts,
than for your whole body to be thrown into gehenna.
30 If your right hand causes your downfall,
cut it off and throw it from you;
for it is better for you to lose one of your body-parts,
than for your whole body to go off into gehenna.

R.T. France

27 You have heard that it was said, "You shall not commit adultery.' **28** But I tell you that every man who looks at someone else's wife and wants to have sex with her has already committed adultery with her in his heart. **29** But if your right eye causes you to stumble, tear it out and throw it away: you are better off losing one part of your body than having your whole body thrown into hell. **30** And if your right hand causes you to stumble, cut it off and throw it away: you are better off losing one part of your body than having your whole body go to hell.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

Jesus is *not* creating a new sin syllogism that equates lust with adultery in a coextensive way. One will often hear interpreters suggest that Jesus is saying that being angry is just as bad as murder, or more commonly that lust is just as bad as adultery. But this is to flatten out the important distinctions and to miss the point of the teaching. Jesus is not making all sins equal; murder and adultery are indeed worse sins with greater social and personal consequences than hating and lusting. The point is not a great equalization of all sins...Rather, these heart-focused exegeses reveal the true depth of the matter. They are a strong push against the human tendency to focus on external actions and make godliness a matter of appropriate behavior regardless of the heart's intent. The broad and easy way is the way of external religion, not that of whole-person righteousness (7:13–14). At the most practical level, if anger and lust are to be understood coextensively as the same as murder and adultery, then at best we would have no leaders or pastors...and at worst we would need to stone most men.

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.187*

[Lust] takes an appetite which, in lawful use, leads the individual out of himself to complete (and correct) his own personality in that of another ... and turns it back: sending the man back into the prison of himself, there to keep a harem of imaginary brides. And this harem, once admitted, works against his ever getting out and really uniting with a real woman. For the harem is always accessible, always subservient, calls for no sacrifice or adjustments ... In the end, they become merely the medium through which he increasingly adores himself....
The true exercise of imagination, in my view, is (a) To help us to understand other people (b) To respond to, and, some of us, to produce art. But it has also a bad use: to provide for us, in shadowy form, a substitute for virtues, successes, distinctions, et cetera which ought to be sought outside in the real world...the main work of life is to come out of our selves, out of the little, dark prison we are all born in. Masturbation is to be avoided as all things are to be avoided which retard this process. The danger is that of coming to love the prison.... Disgust, self-contempt, self-hatred–rhetoric against the sin and (still more) vilification of sexuality or the body in themselves–are emphatically not the weapons for this warfare. We must be relieved, not horrified, by the fact that the whole thing is humiliating, undignified, ridiculous; the lofty vices would be far worse. ... The sin, if we fall into it, must be repented, like all our others. God will forgive. The temptation is a darn nuisance, to be borne with patience as long as God wills.

— C.S. Lewis, *Yours, Jack: Spiritual Direction from C.S. Lewis, pp.292–293, 307–308*

OLD TESTAMENT Genesis 39:2–23 (Robert Alter)

[Relevance: Eye and hand reaching for the forbidden sin against God; what he places in hands is gift, anything else seized comes from our desire.]

> And the Lord was with Joseph and he was a successful man, and he was in the house of his Egyptian master. And his master saw that the LORD was with him, and all he did the LORD made succeed in his hand, and Joseph found favor in his eyes and he ministered to him, and he put him in charge of his house, and all that he had he placed in his hands. And it happened from the time he put him in charge of his house and of all he had, that the LORD had blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake and the LORD's blessing was on all that he had in house and field. And he left all that he had in Joseph's hands, and he gave no thought to anything with him there save the bread he ate. And Joseph was comely in features and comely to look at.
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> And it happened after these things that his master's wife raised her eyes to Joseph and said, "Lie with me." And he refused. And he said to his master's wife, "Look, my master has given no thought with me here to what is in the house, and all that he has he has placed in my hands. He is not greater in this house than I, and he has held back nothing from me except you, as you are his wife, and how could I do this great evil and give offense to God?" And so she spoke to Joseph day after day, and he would not listen to her, to lie by her, to be with her. And it happened, on one such day, that he came into the house to perform his task, and there was no man of the men of the house there in the house. And she seized him by his garment, saying "Lie with me." And he left his garment in her hand and he fled and went out. AN so, when she saw that he had left his garment in her hand and fled outside, she called out to the people of the house and said to them, saying, "See, he has brought us a Hebrew man to play with us. He came into me to lie with me and I called out in a loud voice, and so, when he heard me raise my voice and call out, he left his garment by me and fled and went out." And she laid out his garment by her until his master returned to his house. And she spoke to him things of this sort, saying "The Hebrew slave came into me, whom you brought us, to play with me. And so, when I raised my voice and called out, he left his garment by me and fled outside." And it happened, when his master heard his wife's word which she spoke to him, saying, "Things of this sort your slave has done to me," he became incensed. And Joseph's master took him and placed him in the prison-house, the place where the king's prisoners were held.
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> And he was there in the prison-house, and God was with Joseph and extended kindness to him, and granted him favor in the eyes of the prison-house warden. And the prison-house warden placed in Joseph's hands all the prisoners who were in the prison-house, and all that they were to do there, it was he who did it. The prison-house warden had to see to nothing that was in his hands, as the LORD was with him, and whatever he did, the LORD made succeed.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. If Jesus makes hyperbolic statements to reveal the seriousness of sin, is avoiding sin the true *telos* of the Christian ethic? If not, what is?
2. What about lust makes it incongruous with the kingdom of heaven? i.e., how does our vision of others get distorted?
3. Does something fundamentally change with our relationship to God when we lust?
4. What do we lose when we separate lust and adultery? What do we lose when we equate them?

JOURNAL NOTES

27 You have heard that it was said, 'You shall not commit adultery.' **28** But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart. **29** If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body be thrown into hell. **30** And if your right hand causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. For it is better that you lose one of your members than that your whole body go into hell.

(ESV)

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (PT.2) (NET)

a **31** It was said,
b ‘Whoever divorces his wife
c must give her a legal document.’
a’ **32** But I say to you that
b’ everyone who divorces his wife,
? except for immorality,
c’ makes her commit adultery (moicheuthēnai),
b” and whoever marries a divorced woman
c” commits adultery (moichatai).

INDIVIDUALS’ TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

31 It **has also been said**,
“Whoever sends away his wife,
he must give her a certificate of divorce.”

32 **And I say to you that**
everyone who sends away his wife,
—except on the grounds of sexual immorality—
he makes her a victim of adultery,
and whoever marries a sent-away-woman
he commits adultery

COMMENTARY QUOTES

The concept of a man and wife as “one flesh” which will be the basis of Jesus’ rejection of divorce in 19:4–9 stands in tension with the fact that an act of adultery sets up a “one-flesh” relationship with a different person. In Jewish thought this second “one-flesh” union was understood to violate the original one so radically that the subsequent continuation of the original marriage was unthinkable; it was officially dissolved...In the OT the marriage was terminated by the death penalty for adultery, but by Jesus’ time the death penalty was not normally imposed; instead the marriage was legally dissolved. The termination of a marriage already destroyed by the act of adultery was thus not so much “divorce” (a man’s voluntary repudiation of his wife) as the necessary recognition that the original marriage no longer existed, that a new “one-flesh” union was already a *fait accompli*.
...
This interpretation perhaps gains support from the way the prohibition of divorce is expressed, as the initiation of adultery. With regard to the woman, it makes her the victim of adultery, either in that the husband’s repudiation of a marriage that is intact is itself equated with an act of adultery (since adultery destroys a marriage), or in that when she subsequently remarries (as is provided for in the divorce certificate and is assumed as the sequel to her divorce) she will be placed by her husband’s act in an adulterous relationship, since the original marriage remains valid in the sight of God. So both the divorced wife (the victim of the first husband’s unjust act) and her subsequent husband are involved in an act of adultery — and thus in breaking the seventh commandment, which in its OT context carried the death penalty.
...
[vv.31–32] at least entertains the possibility of a world in which God’s ideal is not always met. In such a world the very underdeveloped damage-limitation provisions of Deut 24:1–4 may continue to have a place...and still continues with our divorce laws today. Such laws have their place in a well-ordered society, but they cannot claim to have the direct sanction of Jesus, and can only claim to fall within the spirit of his teaching if it is their aim not to accept and accommodate human “hardness of heart” but rather to uphold the standard of unbroken, lifelong marriage which God designed and to oppose the human tendency to make it easier to “separate what God has joined together”.

— R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew, pp.210–212*

The verb here, [moicheuein], is normally used in the active of a man committing adultery and in the passive of a woman committing adultery. But the active could refer to a woman’s role in adultery, especially in a statement that did not intend to be gender-specific. This opens up the possibility that the passive form, obviously available to express the idea that a man might be the victim of adultery through the action of his wife, might also be used to express this new thought that the woman as well might be the victim of adultery through the action of her husband...What is being asserted, then, is that, in divorcing, the man is not creating a clean slate with freedom to remarry; on the contrary, his establishment of a new relationship will be an act of adultery against his spurned wife.

— John Nolland, *The Gospel of Matthew: A Commentary on the Greek Text, pp.243–244*

In Matt. 19:3–12 the reader is given another opportunity to understand both the heart of what Jesus is teaching and some of its implications. In chapter 19 the Pharisees attempt to test and entrap him in a theological and/or rhetorical blunder that they hope will result in the decline of his popularity at least and, at most, his imprisonment and execution, as happened to his similarly prophetic forerunner, John the Baptist. [The parallels between Jesus’s and John the Baptist’s lives are many and not mere coincidence. This was not lost on the Pharisees, who were increasingly desperate to end Jesus’s growing popularity. It was the issue of divorce, remarriage, and the accusation of adultery that finally got John arrested and beheaded [14:1–12]. Jesus’s opponents would have been quite relieved if Jesus met the same fate.]

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.189, 189n44*

OLD TESTAMENT Malachi 2:10–16 (LXX, my translation)

[Relevance: Divorce is covenant abandonment, which God sees as abandoning his covenant, undermining any faith or worship offered alongside it.]

> **10** Is it not one God who created you? Is it not one father of you all? Why is it that you have each abandoned your brother, so as to profane the covenant of your fathers? **11** Judah was abandoned, and an abomination occurred in Israel and Jerusalem, because Judah profaned the holy things of the Lord, which he loved, and pursued foreign gods. **12** The Lord will utterly destroy the man who does these things, until he is brought low, out of the tents of Jacob and from among those bringing sacrifice to the Lord Almighty. **13** And these things which [I] hated, you kept doing — covering the Lord's altar with tears, with weeping and groaning, from hardships. Is it still worth [his] looking favorably on the sacrifice, or accepting something acceptable from your hands? **14** And you said, 'Why?' Because the Lord bore witness between you and the wife of your youth, whom you abandoned — yet she is your partner and the wife of your covenant. **15** And it was not another who made [her], and [there is] a remnant of his spirit. And you said, 'What else, except that God seeks offspring?' So guard yourselves in your spirit, and do not abandon the wife of your youth. **16** But if, having come to hate her, you send her away, says the Lord God of Israel, then impiety will cover your devisings, says the Lord Almighty. So guard yourselves in your spirit, and by no means abandon [her].

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. What is the "heart issue" in discussion? Is it more than prohibiting a man abandoning his wife? What affects our relationship with God?
2. The main tension here is that apparently divorce is unacceptable, yet with exception (or exceptions?) acceptable? Why even carve out an exception when making an already bold (if not hyperbolic, cf. Mt. 19) statement? Why would Mk 10 or Lk 16 not include it?
3. If this is Jesus's (extremely conservative) view on divorce, why are Christians today (generally) accepting about divorce? Do our "allegiances" to a holy ethic test the mercy of the gospel when talking about divorce?
4. How big of an issue was divorce and remarriage in the early Christian church? Why does Paul seemingly contradict Jesus in 1 Cor. 7?

JOURNAL NOTES

31 It was also said, 'Whoever divorces his wife, let him give her a certificate of divorce.' **32** But I say to you that everyone who divorces his wife, except on the ground of sexual immorality, makes her commit adultery, and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery. (ESV)

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (PT.3) (NET)

a **33** Again, you have heard that it was said to an older generation,
b ‘Do not break an oath, but fulfill your vows to the Lord.’
a’ **34** But I say to you,
b’ do not take oaths at all—
c not by heaven, because it is the throne of God,
c’ **35** not by earth, because it is his footstool,
c” and not by Jerusalem, because it is the city of the great King.
d **36** Do not take an oath by your head, because you are not able to make one hair white or black.
★ **37** Let your word be ‘Yes, yes’ or ‘No, no.’ More than this is from the evil one.

INDIVIDUALS’ TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

33 Again, you have heard that it was said to the ancients,
“Do not break your oath,”
and “Repay to the Lord your vows.”

34 And I tell you,
do not swear an oath at all;
not by the sky,
because it is God’s throne;
35 not by the land,
because it is the stool of his feet;
not by Jerusalem,
because it is the city of the Great King.
36 And do not swear by your head,
for you cannot make even one hair white or black.

37 But let your word be “Yes, yes” or “No, no”;
anything beyond this comes from the evil one.

R.T. France

33 Again, you have heard that was said to people long ago, “You shall not swear falsely,” and “You shall fulfill your oaths to the Lord.” **34** But I tell you: do not swear an oath at all, either by heaven (because it is God’s throne), **35** or by the earth (because it is the footstool for his feet), or by Jerusalem (because it is the city of the great king); **36** and do not swear by your own head, because you cannot make a single hair white or black. **37** Rather, let your words be simply “Yes” and “No”; anything more than that comes from evil.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

[vv.33–37] could reasonably be connected to the much higher value that was placed in the ancient world on one’s speech or words having great power to affect reality. God is a speaking God, and, not insignificantly, he *creates by speaking*. This extends to God’s ongoing creative work through blessing, which is an effecting of reality through speaking, as well as its destructive counterpart, cursing...this understanding of the power of words is easily perverted and twisted into a mechanistic understanding and simultaneously a way to evade true, ethical, whole-person living. This is the matter at hand in Matt. 5:33–37.

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.192*

See Jas 5:12 for a restatement of [v.37]. While Jas 5:12 reflects the *sense* of Jesus’ words here, 2 Cor 1:17, with its doubled [Yes, yes] and [No, no], is closer to their *form*. It uses the phrases in a quite different sense, however, in that the utterance side by side of [Yes, yes] and [No, no] represent the *unreliability* of someone who says sometimes one thing and sometimes another; in that case the repetition of the particle probably indicates emphasis intended to gain credence.

— R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew, p.215n127*

The ethics to which Jesus calls his disciples are those of the kingdom and its perfection. Here a person’s word can be relied upon without qualification and without need of the further guarantee an oath might afford. Oaths are thereby rendered superfluous. With the dawn of the new era comes a wholly new standard of righteousness, one in which yes is really a yes and no is really a no.

— Donald A. Hagner, *Matthew 1–13, pp.128–129*

Jesus’ prohibition on swearing is based on the assumption that God requires truthfulness. A simple Yes or No should be all that is needed. As soon as it is necessary to bolster it with an oath in order to persuade others to believe what is said, the ideal of transparent truthfulness has been compromised. The need for such an addition is “from evil”; it betrays our failure to live up to God’s standard of truthfulness.
...
The majority of references to oaths in the OT, especially in the book of Deuteronomy, are to God’s oath by which he has committed himself to bless his people under his covenant with their ancestors. Is God’s oath then also “from evil”? In one sense it is, in that if people were prepared to trust God’s simple word there would be no need for an oath. But insofar as God’s oath is a powerful statement of his own dependability ..., it differs from human oaths which attempt to enlist God in support of their less dependable words.
...
Jesus’ absolute pronouncement sets out the true will of God, but in human life that will is not always followed, and there is still a place for legal oaths (as for divorce regulations) to cope with the actual untruthfulness of people, even sadly sometimes of disciples. They should not be needed, but in practice they serve a remedial purpose in a world where the ethics of the kingdom are not always followed. Refusal to take a required oath can in such circumstances convey quite the wrong impression. Jesus’ illustrations of the “greater righteousness” are not to be treated as if they were a new set of literal regulations to replace those of the scribes and Pharisees.

— R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew, pp.215–217*

OLD TESTAMENT 1 Samuel 14:24–45 (NASB)

[Relevance: Oaths multiply burdens and strain the relationship with God that they were originally meant to reflect.]

> Now the men of Israel were hard-pressed on that day, for Saul had put the people under oath, saying, "Cursed be the man who eats food before evening, and before I have avenged myself on my enemies." So none of the people tasted food. All the people of the land entered the forest, and there was honey on the ground. When the people entered the forest, behold, there was honey dripping; but no man put his hand to his mouth, because the people feared the oath. However, Jonathan had not heard it when his father put the people under oath; so he put out the end of the staff that was in his hand and dipped it in the honeycomb, and put his hand to his mouth, and his eyes brightened. Then one of the people responded and said, "Your father strictly put the people under oath, saying, 'Cursed be the man who eats food today.'" And the people were weary. Then Jonathan said, "My father has troubled the land. See now that my eyes have brightened because I tasted a little of this honey. How much more, if only the people had freely eaten today of the spoils of their enemies which they found! For now the defeat among the Philistines has not been great."
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> They attacked the Philistines that day from Michmash to Aijalon. But the people were very tired. So the people loudly rushed upon the spoils, and took sheep, oxen, and calves, and slaughtered them on the ground; and the people ate them with the blood. Then observers informed Saul, saying, "Look, the people are sinning against the Lord by eating meat with the blood." And he said, "You have acted treacherously; roll a large rock to me today." Then Saul said, "Disperse yourselves among the people and say to them, 'Each one of you bring me his ox or his sheep, and slaughter it here and eat; and do not sin against the Lord by eating it with the blood.'" So all the people brought them that night, each one his ox with him, and they slaughtered them there. And Saul built an altar to the Lord; it was the first altar that he built to the Lord.
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> Then Saul said, "Let's go down after the Philistines by night and take plunder among them until the morning light, and let's not leave a man among them alive." And they said, "Do whatever seems good to you." So the priest said, "Let's approach God here." So Saul inquired of God: "Shall I go down after the Philistines? Will You hand them over to Israel?" But He did not answer him on that day. Then Saul said, "Come here, all you leaders of the people, and investigate and see how this sin has happened today. For as the Lord lives, who saves Israel, even if it is in my son Jonathan, he shall assuredly die!" But not one of all the people answered him. Then he said to all Israel, "You shall be on one side, and I and my son Jonathan will be on the other side." And the people said to Saul, "Do what seems good to you." Therefore, Saul said to the Lord, the God of Israel, "Give a perfect lot." And Jonathan and Saul were selected by lot, but the people were exonerated. Then Saul said, "Cast lots between me and my son Jonathan." And Jonathan was selected by lot.
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> So Saul said to Jonathan, "Tell me what you have done." And Jonathan told him, and said, "I did indeed taste a little honey with the end of the staff that was in my hand. Here I am, I must die!" And Saul said, "May God do the same to me and more also, for you shall certainly die, Jonathan!" But the people said to Saul, "Must Jonathan die, he who has brought about this great victory in Israel? Far from it! As the Lord lives, not even a hair of his head shall fall to the ground, because he has worked with God this day." So the people rescued Jonathan and he did not die.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. Again, what exactly is the "heart issue" in question here? Is this even a valid interpretive framework past vv.21–25 and vv.26–30?
2. At what point do we lose the original cultural context (where oaths were much more significant) in order to modernize the underlying message? How can we be sure we even have the correct message?
3. (v. 36) Syntactically this looks different, but it is just the same message?
4. Why is trustworthiness (in word specifically) so valuable in the kingdom of heaven that Jesus feels compelled to outright ban oaths (or hyperbolically does so to create the same effect) to ensure trustworthy followers?
5. What makes oath-swearing from evil/the Evil one? Jesus is put under oath in Mt. 26 by the high priest, is it related to that?

JOURNAL NOTES	
33 Again you have heard that it was said to those of old, 'You shall not swear falsely, but shall perform to the Lord what you have sworn.' **34** But I say to you, Do not take an oath at all, either by heaven, for it is the throne of God, **35** or by the earth, for it is his footstool, or by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the great King. **36** And do not take an oath by your head, for you cannot make one hair white or black. **37** Let what you say be simply 'Yes' or 'No'; anything more than this comes from evil. (ESV)	